

Happenings in Handmade

A CCI initiative

August 2023

On the eve of National Handloom Day, good news of a miracle cotton variety

Despite the heartening growth of the handloom market year on year, cotton farmers continue to be haunted by chronic problems - the high cost of production, a lack of access to quality seeds, depleted soil conditions and climate fluctuations. It's become imperative to **find methods of sustainable cotton cultivation**.

One of the more remarkable initiatives is that of **Udaanta**, a brave new trust in Karnataka, formed in 2018 to revive an ancient, naturally brown cotton. Udaanta has named this variety
'Kandu' (pronounced like the proper name, 'Nandu'), which in Kannada means,
very simply, brown.




Kandu



This is a medium-staple, wholly rain-fed, pest- and drought-resistant, robust variety of cotton that thrives in a dry climate. In 2018, one field of this miracle crop was discovered to be still cultivated by a small farmer in a village near Dharwad.

There is more. Kandu naturally supports intercropping with foodgrains, especially lentils, which not only provides the farmer with a second source of income but **fixes nutrients in the soil**.











The soft earthy hue of the cotton requires little or no dyeing, so it is **non-polluting**. It accepts a very few vegetable dyes, sparingly used, such as iron black, crimson alizarin, arecanut and pomegranate (which shows up as yellows).

All of these features of the noble Kandu give the farmer control over his land, his looms and the beautiful final fabric he and his family place in our hands. You could say **this is cotton that is born sustainable**.

Udaanta currently helps cultivate 20 acres of Kandu and hopes to increase it to 100 acres soon.

Now that is something to celebrate, and support, on August 7th.